🪖 World War I: Reading

World History · Unit 4 · Level 3 (closer to the class work) · goes with the Causes of WWI sheet, WWI weapons slides and Treaty of Versailles sheet

Name: _____

The Great War (1914-1918)

Historians remember the long-term causes of World War I with the word MAIN. Militarism: European powers built huge armies and navies. Alliances: countries promised to defend each other, splitting Europe into two armed camps. Imperialism: they competed for colonies in Africa and Asia. Nationalism: extreme pride in one's nation, and the wish of groups like the Serbs to have their own country.

The spark came on June 28, 1914, when a Serbian nationalist shot Archduke Franz Ferdinand, heir to Austria-Hungary's throne, in Sarajevo. Austria-Hungary declared war on Serbia. Because of alliances, the conflict spread like falling dominoes: Russia backed Serbia, Germany backed Austria-Hungary, and France and Britain joined Russia. The Allies (Britain, France, Russia, later the United States) fought the Central Powers (Germany, Austria-Hungary and the Ottoman Empire).

On the Western Front, both sides dug trenches protected by barbed wire and machine guns. Attacks across 'no man's land' gained little ground, and the war became a stalemate. New technology such as tanks, airplanes, submarines and poison gas made it the first modern, industrial war. About 9 million soldiers died.

The United States entered in 1917, and Germany agreed to an armistice on November 11, 1918. At the peace conference, President Wilson proposed his Fourteen Points, including fair treatment of Germany and a League of Nations. France and Britain wanted Germany punished. The Treaty of Versailles (1919) forced Germany to accept blame, give up land and colonies, limit its army and pay huge reparations. Many Germans felt humiliated, which helped set the stage for World War II.

Check your reading

1. What do the letters in MAIN stand for?

2. Why did the war become a stalemate?

3. How did the Treaty of Versailles help lead to WWII?